BÓYÌ 博弈 · WEEK 8

àn dù chén cāng

暗渡陈仓

Cross at Chencang in secret.

More than 2,200 years ago, a long war had just ended and the empire was cut into eighteen kingdoms. The weakest share, on the other side of the mountains, went to one man. His army walked in on a wooden road, and he burned it behind him. For four months, nothing came out of those mountains. In the eighth month, his army came out at Chencang by another road. This week you'll learn to write four characters: 暗, 渡, 陈, 仓.

Stratagem No. 8 of 36 · one story, one lesson, four characters.

本周学：暗渡陈仓 · 练字：暗、渡、陈、仓

A ROAD, BURNED BEHIND HIM



Fire runs along the plank road; the beams drop away one by one.

There is a saying in Chinese: build the road in the open, cross in secret. The old book Shiji never says anyone rebuilt that road.

According to the old book Shiji, this happened more than 2,200 years ago. A long war had just ended, and the empire was cut into eighteen kingdoms.

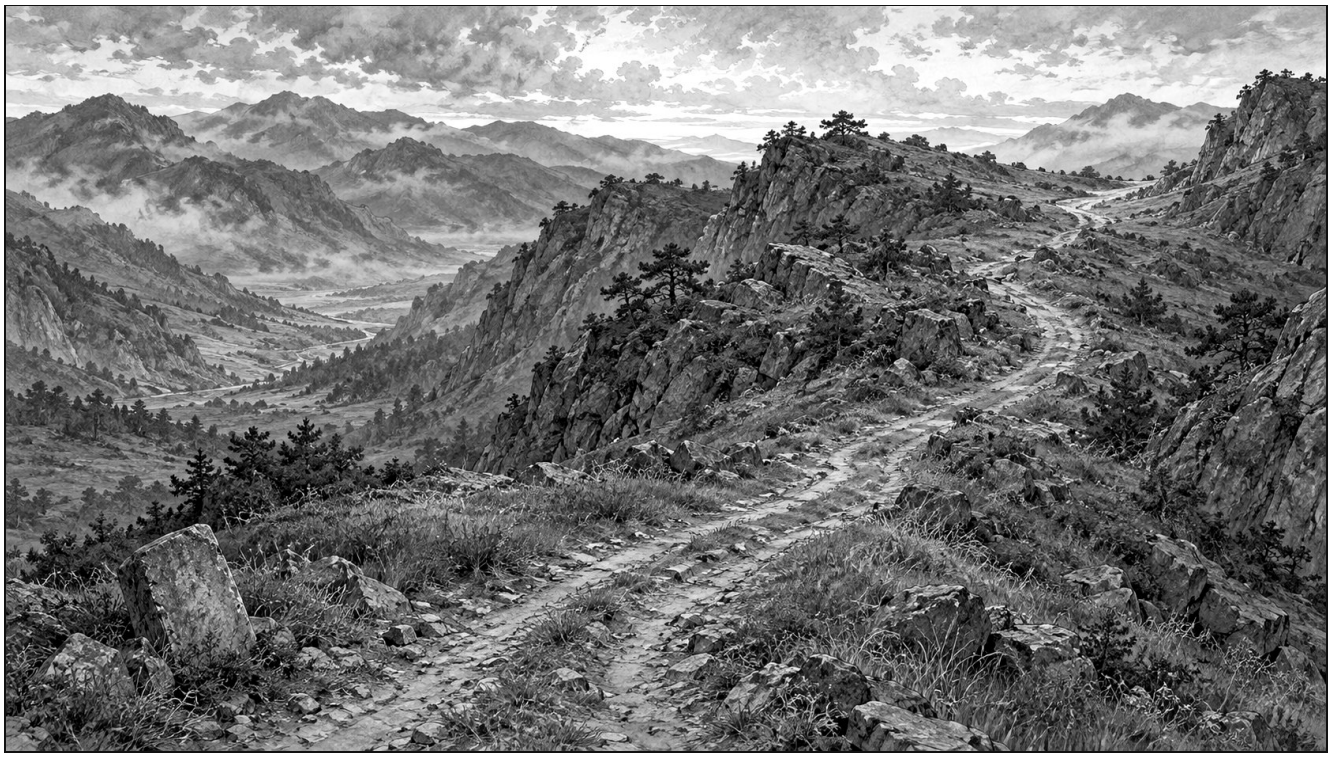
The weakest share went to the farthest corner, on the other side of the mountains. To get there, his army walked a wooden road pinned to a cliff.

When he was through, he burned it behind him. Partly to stop raiders. But mostly, to send one message: I am not coming back.

For four months, nothing came out of those mountains. And the man on the other side stopped thinking about him.

《史记·高祖本纪》

THE OLD ROAD



An old road, half buried in grass.

In the eighth month, an order came. They did not rebuild the road.

They took an old road — the Old Road. It went the long way round: west first, then north.

They came out at Chencang. He fought outside the city, and lost.

He fell back to a second town, and lost there too. He fell back again and again. And the land north of the mountains was Liu Bang's.

A burned road only tells you where the last army went. It says nothing about the next one.

《史记·高祖本纪》

WHY IT WORKED

Step	Who vs who	中文 · pinyin	Result
Look there	A burned road, and one message	暗 àn	He stops watching
Wait	Four months of nothing	渡 dù	Not silence — work
Go here	The Old Road, west then north	陈仓 chén cāng	Chencang, then the north

烧掉的路只说上一支军队从哪儿走。 暗渡陈仓 àn dù chén cāng

THE ORIGINAL LINES

《三十六计·第八计 暗渡陈仓》
The Thirty-Six Stratagems, No. 8 — "Cross at Chencang in secret"

1

shì zhī yǐ dòng
示之以动，
Show movement.

2

lì qí jìng ér yǒu zhǔ
利其静而有主，
Profit when they are quiet and settled.

3

yì dòng ér xùn
益动而巽。

Three lines, nothing more. The last line comes from the I Ching. The long commentary that follows in old editions is not part of this text.

原文只有这三句。末句出自《易经》。后面那段按语是老版本的注释，不进原文框。

PRACTICE · 暗 ÀN · 渡 DÙ

Follow the numbers. Write each stroke in order.

先描一遍分解格，再在田字格里写 5 遍。

暗

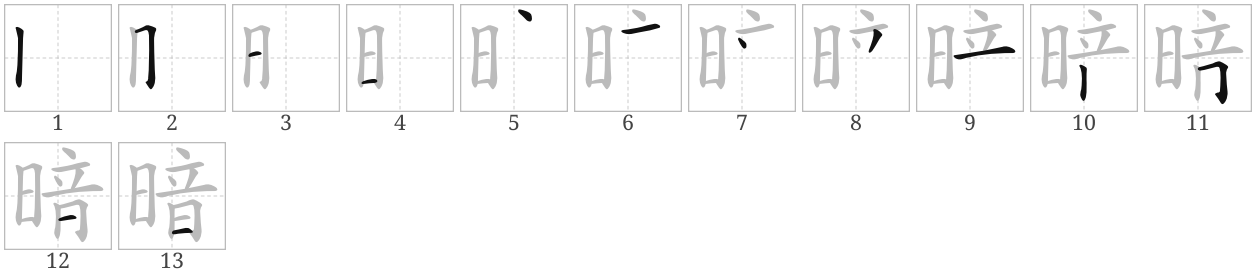


àn

dark; hidden

13 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

渡

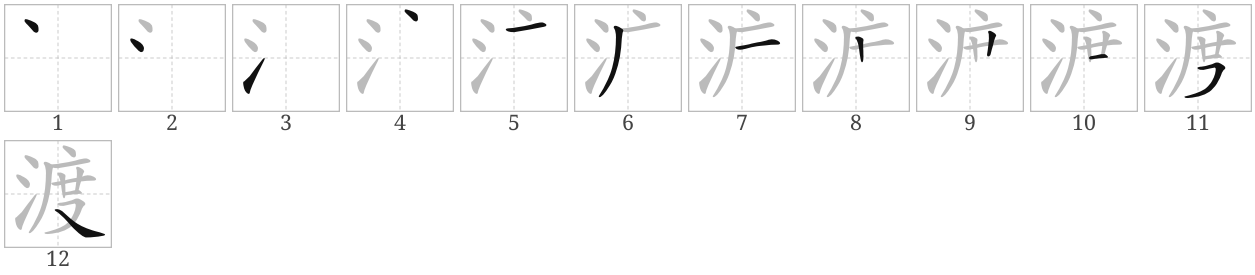


dù

to cross water

12 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

PRACTICE · 陈 CHÉN · 仓 CĀNG

Same order again. Write slowly, and say the sound out loud.

写完 4 个字，再回到第 7 页连写整句。

陈

chén

to lay out; old

7 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

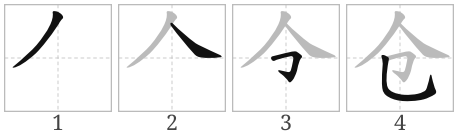
仓

cāng

storehouse

4 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

PRACTICE · 暗渡陈仓 ÀN DÙ CHÉN CĀNG

Trace the first row, then write the whole phrase four times. Say it out loud each time.

àn	dù	chén	cāng
暗	渡	陈	仓

暗渡陈仓 · Cross at Chencang in secret.

THREE MORE WORDS

shāo

1 烧

to burn.

rén yí guò wán tā jiù zài shēn hòu bǎ tā shāo le

人 一 过 完， 他 就 在 身 后 把 它 烧 了。

When he was through, he burned it behind him.

That is what the fire was for. A sentence, not a wall.

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jiù lù

2 旧路

an old road.

tā men zǒu de shì yì tiáo jiù lù — gù

他 们 走 的 是 一 条 旧 路 — — 故 道。

They took an old road — the Old Road.

It went the long way round: west first, then north.

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qī xiàn

3 期限

a deadline.

nà bǐ kòu fèi bú shì piàn jú shì yí gè nǐ bú zài dīng zhe de qī xiàn

那 笔 扣 费 不 是 骗 局， 是 一 个 你 不 再 盯 着 的 期 限 。

The charge was not a trick. It was a deadline you stopped watching.

Nothing was hidden from you. The date was written down.

SPOT IT · STOP IT 识破 · 防住

The trial is still running. The date is still on the page. You can read that page again tonight, and stop it. Or you can tell yourself you will do it tomorrow — and tomorrow is the day it charges.

在造东西 *Quiet that builds*	**在藏东西** *Quiet that hides*
bù tí shēng rì 不 提 生 日 *The birthday is not mentioned*	bù tí rì qī 不 提 日 期 *The date is not mentioned*
zài bǎi pán 在 摆 盘 *The plates are being set*	xiǎo zì zài yè jiǎo 小 字 在 页 脚 *The small print is in the footer*
mén yì kāi shì zhēn de 门 一 开 是 真 的 *It is real when the door opens*	sān shí yī tiān yí dào jiù kòu 三 十 一 天 一 到 就 扣 *Day thirty-one charges*

Two ways to go quiet. One builds something, one hides something. Same silence. Different thing behind it. So, one line: a burned road is not a closed door.

不出声有两种：一种在造东西，一种在藏东西。一样的安静，后面藏着不一样的东西。一句话：烧掉的路，不等于封死的门。

SEVEN DAYS, SEVEN QUESTIONS

Day 1 Which page did you click once, and never read again? 页脚 yè jiǎo

Day 2 What are you waiting for — and is anything being built while you wait? 等 děng

Day 3 What has gone quiet on you, and what is behind that quiet? 安静 ān jìng

Day 4 Which deadline did you stop watching? 期限 qī xiàn

Day 5 What did you burn behind you, and who stopped looking? 烧 shāo

Day 6 When someone is quiet, is that work or is that hiding? 藏 cáng

Day 7 Which road are you sure is closed — and which one are you not watching? 旧路 jiù lù

WEEK 8 REVIEW



The one-page summary of this week. 本周一图总结。

1. In one sentence: why did he burn the road behind him?

2. What does 暗渡陈仓 mean, in your own words?

3. Which of this week's four characters can you write now without looking: 暗, 渡, 陈, or 仓?

4. Think of a road you are sure is closed. When did you last walk up and check it?

Which door are you assuming is shut — and when did anyone actually try it?
哪扇门你以为是关死的？上一次有人真去推它，是什么时候?
Nǎ shàn mén nǐ yǐ wéi shì guān sǐ de? Shàng yí cì yǒu rén zhēn qù tuī tā, shì shén me shí hou?

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